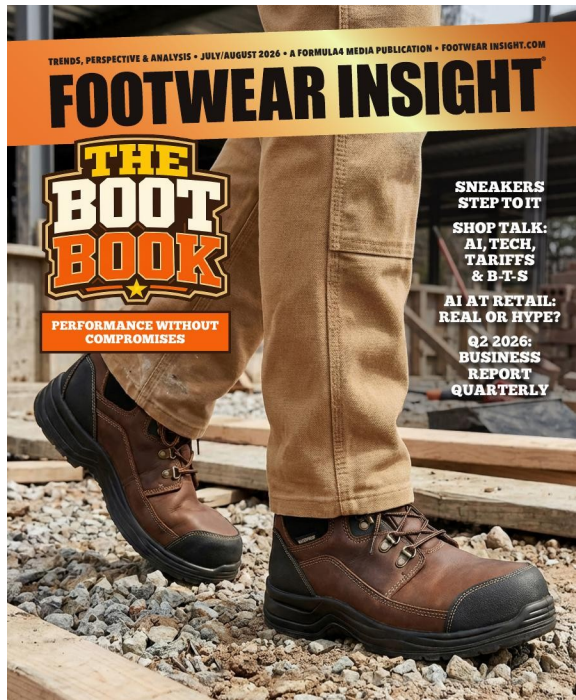


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1. $\square\square - \square\square \& \square\square\square \square\square$

□□ □□ □The Boot Book: Performance Without Compromises□□ □□□□□□ □□□ □□□ □□□ □□□□. □□ □□□ □□ □□□ □□□□ □□□(Step To It), □□ □□□□ □□□(Shop Talk: AI·□□·□□·□□ □□), AI □□ □□ □□(The AI-Powered Shoe Store), 2026 □ 2 □□ □□ □□□(Business Report Quarterly)□.

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2. 鞋之眼 (The Footwear Eye)

- ECCO 8 月 月 月 'ECCO Elevate' 月 月 月. 月·月·月 月 月 月 月 140~150 月.
- Allbirds 月 月 'Smartbird' 月 AI 月 月 月 月. 月 月 月 American Exchange Group 月 3,900 月 月 WSG Brands 月 月 月.
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- 〇〇 〇〇 〇〇: Columbia Sportswear 〇 SOREL 〇〇 〇〇〇 Joe Vernachio(〇 Allbirds CEO) 〇〇. Brooks Running・LOWA USA・Cabot Hosiery・OrthoLite 〇〇〇〇 〇〇〇 〇〇〇〇.
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THE FOOTWEAR EYE



NEW LINE
ECCO Elevate
Reimagines Comfort

In August, ECCO is launching a new women's collection called ECCO Elevate that aims to "re-imagine" what comfort looks like. The collection offers timeless silhouettes with contemporary appeal. Elevate includes suede loafers with metal hardware, low-wedge Mary Janes, block-heel pumps and ballerina flats with contrast cap toes. Designed for women, each style features a softly cushioned leather footbed and a thoughtfully designed fit, balancing elegance with everyday wearability. Styles in the line are designed with the foot's natural shape in mind, bringing together considered comfort and modern style. With Elevate, the Danish brand aims to move beyond dress codes, occasions and seasons, offering a fresh perspective on formal footwear. Elevate styles include details such as smooth black leather, sumptuous camel suede, and rich red and made patent leather finishes, bringing texture and modern sophistication to classic shapes. Suggested retail prices for footwear in the ECCO Elevate collection range from \$140-\$150.

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PARTNERSHIP... THE CORNERSTONE OF ALL GREAT RELATIONSHIPS.



Soles4Souls: the collection bins after five hours of sorting & bagging.

NST and friends making it happen at Soles4Souls.

So many things in life are better with a friend. Long road trips, going to a baseball game, a shopping trip, are all more enjoyable when you've got a friend along to share the fun. If you've got a home project, a friend can help the job get done more quickly and with less stress than if you were working solo.

That's how it is with National Shoe Travelers and their partnerships. The established, long running relationships with manufacturers, vendors, retailers, trade show coordinators and other organizations that help the shoe industry are vital to helping NST members. You can't move a heavy piece of furniture with one person, but get a couple of friends in the mix and now you can get it to where it needs to go.

Much of what NST does, it could not do alone. It is with the help of its partner Two Ten that it can offer members and their families college scholarships. Through partner Soles4Souls, people who can't afford new footwear are provided with shoes as well as clothing and accessories.

"One of our key partnerships is with the Two Ten Footwear Foundation, a non-profit within the footwear industry," said NST President Ken Sollie. "They manage our endowment for NST membership, which supports college scholarships and financial hardship programs."

Through partnership, Sollie said, Two Ten manages, facilitates and mirrors its own programs to help NST maintain integrity through privacy, efficiency, and confidentiality. NST has partnerships with other organizations representing the shoe industry like the Footwear Distributors & Retailers of America, the National Shoe Retailers Association and United Shoe Retailers Association help to ensure that all segments of the shoe industry are working together to keep it thriving.

Many of the shoe shows around the country partner with NST, including the Michigan Shoe Show, the Bluegrass Buyers Market, the Chicago Shoe Market, IR Show, and Minneapolis Show. Those Handshakes allow NST to make connections with traveling shoe reps and hear and understand their needs.

In the shoe business it is all about making friends. NST is growing those partnerships to benefit our members and to foster the ever-changing shoe industry.

"We are truly THANKFUL for all of our partnerships!" Sollie said.

For more information about National Shoe Travelers, visit mynst.org. NST is a non-profit organization helping traveling sales representatives in the shoe industry.

If you're not already a member, what are you waiting for? Join today at mynst.org



〇〇 p.8-9 — ECCO Elevate 〇〇〇 〇 〇〇 〇〇〇〇 〇〇

3. Shop Talk — 〇〇 〇〇〇〇〇 〇〇〇 AI・〇〇・〇〇・〇〇 〇〇

Beck's Shoes, Abbadabba's, The Heel Shoe Fitters, Lucky Shoes, Dardano's Shoes, Lamey Wellehan, Tenni-Moc's 〇 〇〇 〇〇 〇〇 〇〇〇〇 〇〇〇〇〇.

- AI: 〇〇〇 〇〇・〇〇〇 〇〇〇 〇〇・〇〇 〇〇 〇〇 〇〇 〇〇 〇. 〇〇〇〇 "AI 〇 〇〇〇 〇〇〇〇 〇 〇〇〇 〇〇 〇〇 〇〇〇〇 〇〇"〇〇 〇 〇〇〇.
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INDEPENDENT RETAILERS WEIGH IN ON HOT TOPICS. BY BOB MCGEE

FROM AI & TECH TO TARIFFS & BACK-TO-SCHOOL BIZ



Abbadabba's.

With the Summer Solstice in the rearview mirror, we reached out to independent shoe retailers to get their respective takes on four key issues — Artificial Intelligence, Store Technology, Tariffs, and their Back-To-School business. AI was all the buzz in Q2, particularly on Wall Street, given the growing global investments in it and proclamations about how it might alter both the business environment and individual job responsibilities in the months and years ahead. According to reports, more organizations are shifting

away from premium-priced AI models in favor of "model routing," which sends simple tasks to cheaper, open-source, or local Chinese AI models. Meanwhile, there is mounting momentum for federal oversight of AI and calls for regulation on how data centers utilize the U.S. power grid.

Whether they embrace some aspect of AI today or not, most retailers — no matter the size of their business — realize the need to continue embracing and utilizing technology to improve efficiency and, quite frankly, keep up with the times we are living in. As for tariffs, they created widespread

sticker shock across the fashion industry last summer. Retail prices jumped up more than 4 percent a year ago on key footwear brands amid a mad scramble by some manufacturers to shift their sourcing to new markets and avoid steep duties on China-made products. In late February, the U.S. Supreme Court invalidated tariffs imposed through the International Emergency Economic Power Act (IEEPA) by the Trump Administration. But today, nearly five months later, fallout from tariffs — everything from consumer class-action lawsuits to enduring supply chain disruptions in some circles — persists.

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AI AT INDEPENDENT RETAIL

Q Is any aspect of your business utilizing AI? If so, how, and is it making operations easier? If not, do you see yourself implementing it soon?

"We've begun integrating AI into several areas of our business and see it becoming an increasingly important part of retail operations moving forward. Today, we are utilizing AI to help improve internal communication, assist with reporting, streamline content creation for marketing, and support leadership development by helping organize and summarize business data faster. What excites me most is not replacing people, but allowing our teams to spend less time on administrative work and more time focused on what matters most, serving customers and creating exceptional in-store experiences. We believe AI will become a major efficiency driver for independent retailers over the next few years."

Adam Beck, Beck's Shoes

"We are mostly using AI software with our merchandise team. This will be a huge improvement for analyzing sales and inventory data."

Troy Dempsey, The Heel Shoe Fitters

"We began over a year ago using AI to rewrite and update our handbook. It made the overhaul quick, consistent, and easier to read and understand. It gave the handbook a much clearer perspective and a central theme that reinforced our culture and our mission. We are currently experimenting with AI technology to analyze selling reports that can guide us in at-once replenishment, markdowns, and our future commitments, as well as for marketing ideation and tracking trends."

Abba Carmichael, Abbadabba's

"We use AI to create marketing materials that were previously difficult to create, and we also utilize it to raise our scores online [Google]."

John Luck, Lucky Shoes

"We are actively using AI in several areas of the business. For us, the biggest value has been speed and organization. We

use AI to help with product content, internal communications, process documentation, marketing concepts, lifestyle images, data cleanup, reporting support, writing code, and general problem-solving across the business. That said, we view AI as a tool, not a replacement for the human side of retail. Our business is still built around expert service, fit knowledge, relationship building, and hands-on problem-solving. AI has helped remove friction from the back office so our team can spend more time focused on customers."

Dillon Dardano, Dardano's Shoes

"No. We would love to make some of our processes more intelligent and even automated, but that leap into technology is daunting. I can half-jokingly say that we are still trying to stop our VCR from flashing 88.88 all the time..."

Chris Stanley, Lamey Wellehan



Beck's Shoes.

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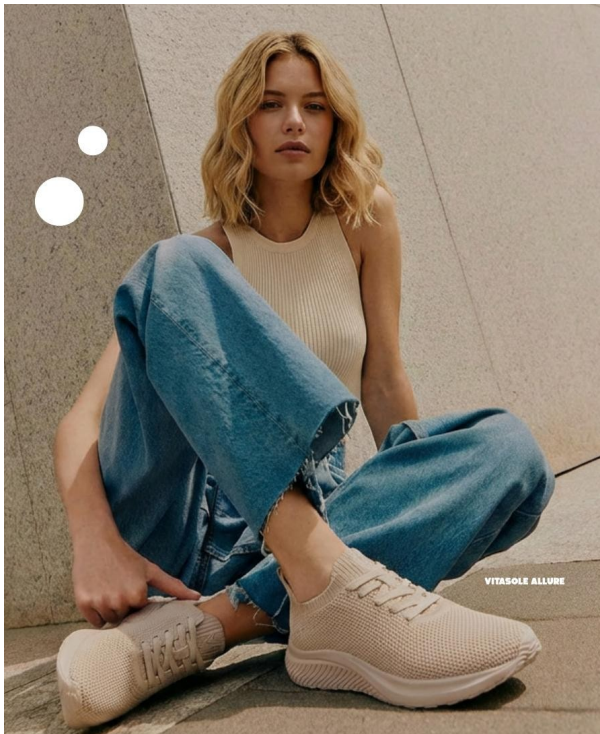
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pp.16-17 — Shop Talk: 零售业的热门话题

4. Step To It — 零售业的热门话题

随着夏季的过去，我们向独立鞋类零售商了解了他们对四个关键问题的看法——人工智能、门店技术、关税以及返校业务。人工智能在第二季度尤为热门，特别是在华尔街，鉴于全球对其投资的增长以及关于它可能会如何改变商业环境和个体工作职责的声明。据报道，越来越多的组织正在转向

从昂贵的AI模型转向“模型路由”，将简单任务转向更便宜、开源或本地中国AI模型。与此同时，对于联邦对人工智能的监管呼声日益高涨，人们呼吁制定法规，以规范数据中心如何利用美国的电力。无论他们今天是否采用人工智能，大多数零售商——无论其企业规模大小——都意识到继续拥抱和利用技术以提高效率并，坦率地说，跟上我们生活的时代。至于关税，它们造成了广泛的



STEP TO IT.

**MAKE
MOVEMENT
A PRIORITY
WITH HIGH
PERFORMING,
STYLISH
SNEAKERS.**

BY SUZANNE BLECHER

Back in the 1830s, canvas shoes with rubber soles were created to walk on sand. About 30 years later, croquet players began wearing rubber-soled shoes. With innovators catching on to the idea into the 1900s, sneakers were adapted to multiple sports including basketball, running and tennis. Through it all, interest in healthy feet and ease of movement has remained intact.

Today's everyday sneakers have evolved tremendously. Packed with innovation, they are still built on the same premise of delivering performance and comfort. "People want a lightweight construction, responsive cushioning, and all-day wearability that supports movement without feeling technical," explains Nick Myers, marketing manager, Alegria. The exec says that the current expectation is for "invisible

p.24-25 — Step To It

5. Boot Book: "No Compromises" —

Warson XTR Extra Wide Toe Box, Red Wing IronFlex(BOA), HexArmor ChromeX1, Juno Jones, Leeza

ECCO·Taos·Blundstone·Remonte, The North Face Fastpack Mid, Xtratuf Ankle Deck Boot, Blundstone Terrain Series(Avalon Gecko TPU)

THE AI-POWERED SHOE STORE WHAT IS REAL AND WHAT IS HYPE?

By Alan Mikolajsky

Arificial Intelligence has become the hottest buzzword in retail. Attend an industry conference, open a trade publication, or sit through a software demonstration and you'll quickly hear promises that AI will revolutionize everything from inventory management to customer service. Some of those promises are real. Many are not.

As someone who has spent nearly five decades in retail, I have witnessed numerous technology waves arrive with great fanfare. Point-of-sale systems, customer relationship management software, e-commerce, mobile commerce, loyalty programs, and social media were all hailed as game-changing innovations. Some fulfilled their promise. Others became expensive distractions.

AI falls into both categories. The challenge for footwear retailers is

determining which applications create measurable value and which are simply marketing hype dressed in futuristic language.

What AI Actually Is

Many retailers imagine AI as a digital employee capable of making sophisticated business decisions. In reality, today's AI is better described as an advanced analytical tool.

AI excels at processing large amounts of information, identifying patterns, making predictions, generating content, and automating repetitive tasks. It does not replace human judgment. It does not understand your customers as well as you do. It does not possess decades of merchandising experience.

Think of AI as a very smart assistant rather than a replacement for management. The retailers who understand this distinction are finding practical ways to improve profitability.

Inventory Management:

The Biggest Opportunity

Perhaps the most valuable application of AI in footwear retail is inventory management. Every retailer struggles with the same challenge: carrying enough inventory to satisfy customers without tying up excessive capital in slow-moving merchandise.

AI systems can analyze years of sales history, seasonal trends, size curves, vendor lead times, weather patterns, promotional activity, and local market conditions. Using that information, they can help predict future demand with greater accuracy than traditional methods.

Will AI completely eliminate inventory mistakes? Of course not.

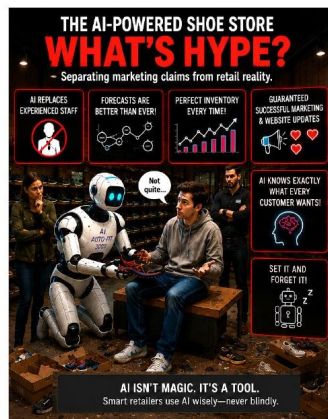
However, even modest improvements can have significant financial impact. Reducing overstocks by a few percentage points while simultaneously decreasing stock-outs can improve cash flow, increase inventory turns, and enhance customer satisfaction.

Those are real benefits that directly affect the bottom line.



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Marketing Content Creation

One area where AI has rapidly become useful is content generation.

Many independent retailers struggle to maintain a consistent flow of social media posts, email newsletters, blog articles, product descriptions, and website updates. Creating content takes time, and most retailers are already stretched thin.

AI tools can draft social media posts, promotional emails, product summaries, and educational content in seconds.

The key word is "draft."

The most successful retailers are not allowing AI to replace their voice. Instead, they use it as a starting point. Human review remains essential to ensure accuracy, maintain brand personality,

and avoid generic messaging.

Customers still want authentic communication. AI can help create it faster, but authenticity remains a human responsibility.

Customer Service Applications

Chatbots have become one of the most visible AI applications. The good news is that they are improving rapidly.

Modern AI-powered chat systems can answer routine questions regarding store hours, return policies, product availability, and shipping status. They can provide assistance 24 hours a day without requiring additional staffing.

The bad news is that many retailers assume chatbots can replace human interaction.

Footwear is a highly personal purchase. Customers often seek advice regarding fit, comfort, medical conditions, activity levels, and lifestyle needs. Those conversations frequently require empathy, experience, and nuanced understanding.

A chatbot may answer basic questions efficiently, but it cannot replicate the value of a knowledgeable footwear professional who understands both products and people.

The future is likely a hybrid model where AI handles routine inquiries while store associates focus on higher-value customer interactions.

Pricing and Promotion Analysis

AI can also assist retailers in evaluating pricing strategies.

Many systems can analyze sales velocity, gross margin performance, inventory levels, and competitive pricing. They can identify products that may benefit from promotional activity and highlight categories where pricing adjustments might improve profitability.

This does not mean AI should determine every markdown or promotion.

Experienced retailers understand factors that software cannot always quantify. Brand positioning, customer perception, vendor relationships, and long-term strategic objectives often influence pricing decisions.

AI provides valuable information. Management provides context. Together they make better decisions.

The Biggest Hype:

Fully Autonomous Retail

Some technology providers suggest that AI will soon run stores with minimal human involvement. This is where the hype begins to exceed reality.

Footwear retailing remains fundamentally relationship-driven. Successful retailers understand local communities, build customer trust, coach employees, solve problems, and create memorable shopping experiences.

No algorithm can replicate decades of accumulated judgment. No software can replace the emotional connection that develops when a customer consistently receives excellent service from knowledgeable associates.

The stores that thrive in the future will not be

□□ p.58-59 — AI □□□ □□ □□ □ □□□□□

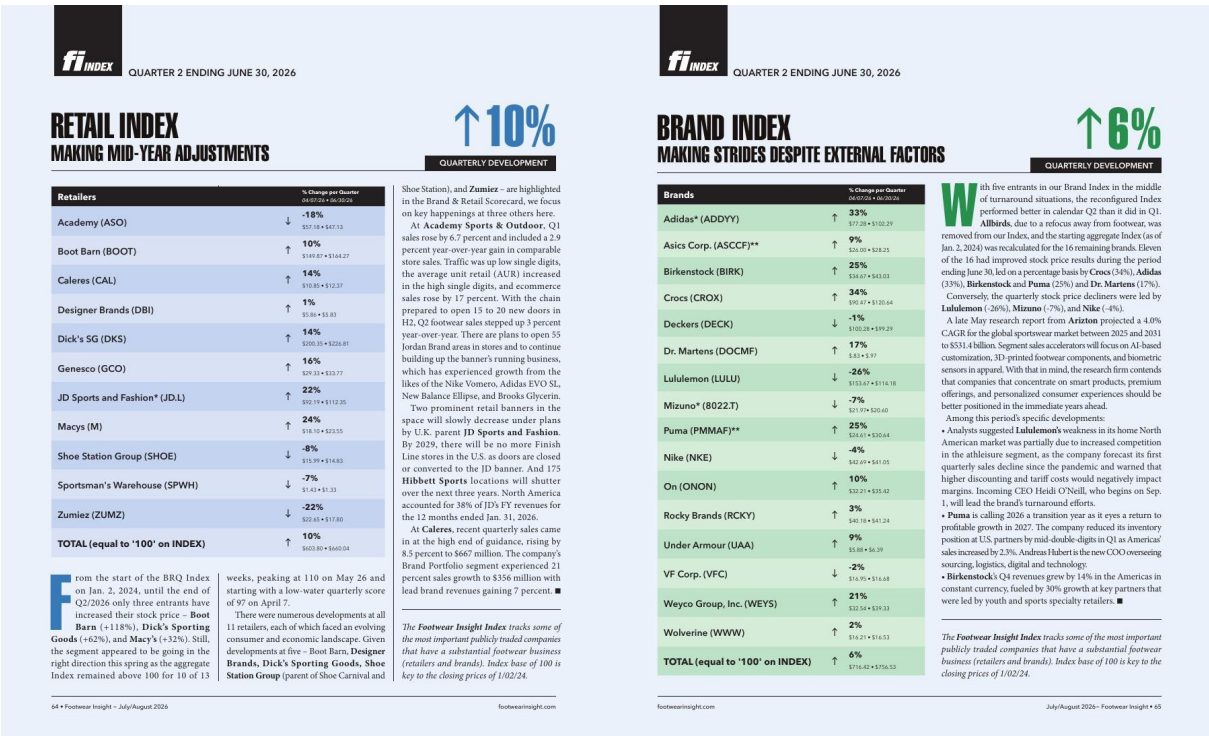
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Retail	Retail Index □□	+10%
Retail	JD Sports and Fashion	+22%
Retail	Macy's	+24%
Retail	Genesco	+16%
Retail	Zumiez	-22%
Retail	Academy Sports + Outdoor	-18%
Brand	Brand Index □□	+6%
Brand	Crocs	+34%
Brand	Adidas	+33%
Brand	Puma / Birkenstock	+25%
Brand	Lululemon	-26%
Brand	Nike	-4%

2024 10월 10일 10월 10일 10월 10일 Boot Barn(+118%), Dick's Sporting Goods(+62%), Macy's(+32%) 10월 10일. Allbirds 10월 10일 10월 10일 Brand Index 10월 10일. Nike, adidas, On, Deckers(HOKA·UGG), Crocs, Skechers, VF Corp, Foot Locker 10월 10일 10월 10일 p.66-69 10월 10일 10월 10일.



10월 10일 p.64-65 — Retail Index / Brand Index 10월 10일

8. Trend Insight — 10월 10일 10월 10일: 2026 10월 10일 10월 10일

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TREND INSIGHT

FALL/WINTER FOCUS: CONSUMER SHOPPING EXPECTATIONS



This survey, conducted by MESEB, included 335 respondents, men and women, aged 18-45. Trend Insight is a partner within Footwear Insight that delivers research conducted on the MESEB Platform. MESEB collects data from a select pool of active and outdoor enthusiasts.

In our latest Trend Insight survey, we asked 335 consumers about their footwear shopping expectations, with a particular focus on the upcoming Fall/Winter season. The top five categories of footwear consumers expect to shop for this Fall/Winter are, in order: running shoes, sneakers, hiking/outdoor boots, athletic-inspired lifestyle shoes and winter/snow boots.

Nearly 70% of the men and women surveyed say they are either somewhat or very concerned about footwear prices this year, with 61% saying if prices increase this Fall/Winter they will "wait for a sale" and 14% saying they'll "buy fewer pairs."

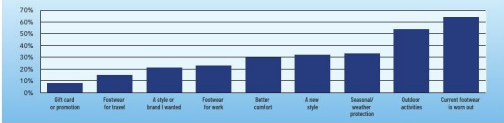
Regarding brick-and-mortar

footwear shopping, the top reasons given for shopping in physical stores are to try on before buying (92%), followed by confidence in fit (53%) and immediate availability (52%). Services that make consumers more likely to shop in-store are led by expert fitting (50%), return policy (49%) and loyalty rewards (47%).

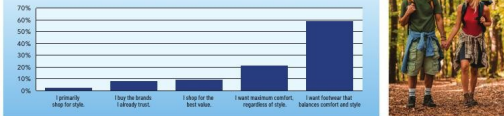
The top factors that shoppers tell us determine which shoes they end up purchasing? Comfort leads the way (87%), followed by fit (79%) and price (70%).

SEIZE THE TREND!

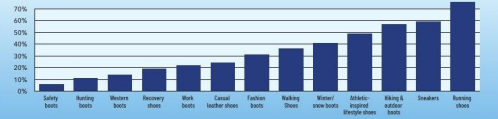
What is the primary reason you'll purchase footwear this Fall/Winter?



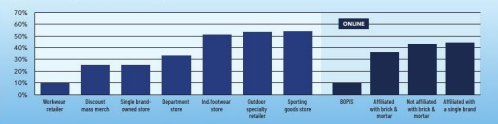
When buying footwear for Fall/Winter, which statement best describes your priorities?



Which types of footwear do you expect to shop for this Fall/Winter?



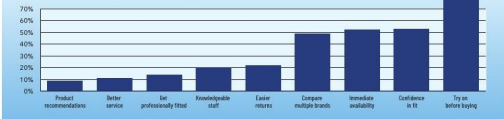
Where do you typically shop for footwear?



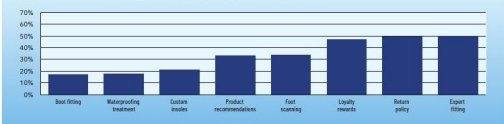
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Why do you choose to shop in a physical store?



Which services would make you MORE likely to purchase from a local retailer?



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□□ p.70-71 — Trend Insight □□□ □□ □□

9. Lines We Like — □□□ □□□

Merrell MTL SpeedARC Peak(□□ □□□ □□□□□□□□, 290 □□), Astral Loyak All Weather 2.0(□□ □□□ □□□□, 140 □□), Teva Trailpeak·Aventrail □□□(□□□□ □□ □□ □□) □ □□·□□ □□□ □□□□ □□□□.

Lines We Like

SOMETHING NEW... DIVING A LITTLE DEEPER WITH THESE INNOVATIVE DESIGNS.



MERRELL. The new MTL SpeedARC Peak is a technical trail running shoe built for elite runners. It features a SpeedARC midsole system, with a three-layer design that delivers efficiency and comfort. Built with FlexPlate cushioning technology, a top layer of PEBAX-based racing foam provides responsive cushioning through long miles, while a more durable base layer ensures resilience on rugged terrain. Between them, lightweight carbon fiber FlexPlate technology delivers populsive energy return with its forked construction that allows the forefoot to adapt independently to uneven terrain, balancing agility and control. MSRP \$290.



ASTRAL. Expanding on its best-selling Loyak series, Astral is launching the Loyak All Weather 2.0 for Fall 2026. It's a waterproof, all-weather evolution of the minimalist all-weather. Built on a boot-inspired, natural foot, the All Weather 2.0 delivers durability, grip, breathability, and ground feel in any condition. G15 Rubber and Flex Grip outsole provide traction, while Astral's Balanced Geometry keeps the foot in its natural position for improved balance and stability thanks to its zero-drop profile, Level footbed, and wider toe box. The shoe is lined with a PBA-free waterproof and breathable membrane and is constructed using a 100% recycled (rPET) upper shell. It also has a 3.5mm lined removable sockliner. MSRP \$140.



TEVA. The outdoor brand continues to dive further into trail running in Fall 2026, with a lineup that includes the first product co-created with Teva Bureau of Adventure (TBA), the lightweight and responsive Trailpeak trail running shoe. MSRP \$160. Additionally, Fall 2026 marks the next chapter for Teva's Aventura line with the introduction of the Aventura Road 2 Trail Shoe (MSRP \$160), joining the Aventura R2T Trail Shoe (MSRP \$160). Aventura Road 2 Trail Shoe (MSRP \$160), and Aventura Road 2 Trail Shoe (MSRP \$160). The new Aventura R2T Shoe builds on the brand's road-to-trail ethos, combining the confidence and traction needed for dirt with the comfort and efficiency runners expect on pavement.

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